

Prepare the Way for the Lord!

Luke 3:2-6

The word of God came to John son of Zechariah in the wilderness. He went into all the country around the Jordan, preaching a baptism of repentance for the forgiveness of sins. As it is written in the book of the words of Isaiah the prophet: "A voice of one calling in the wilderness, 'Prepare the way for the Lord, make straight paths for him. Every valley shall be filled in, every mountain and hill made low. The crooked roads shall become straight, the rough ways smooth. And all people will see God's salvation.'"

In the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.

Prophets had an important job in the Old Testament. One of God's prophets was tasked with preaching and teaching to the people, sort of like a pastor. But prophets had the added responsibility of telling the people about the promises of God that would come true in the future. Prophets especially had the job of telling people about the coming Savior. They had to get the people ready to meet that Savior when he arrived!

John the Baptist had this same role. Sometimes people call him "the last Old Testament prophet," even though we read about him in the New Testament. But John was blessed in a way that no other prophet had been—John got to prophesy the coming of the Savior AND see that Savior also arrive.

John knew that Jesus was just around the corner, so he preached boldly, and he preached without apologizing: Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is near. Make straight paths for Jesus. Clear out all the debris and brush that's blocking the way. Jesus is going to be entering into the world and into your heart. What would make it difficult to reach you? Find out what those things are and get rid of them. Bring your sins in prayer to God. Confess your selfishness to him. Make the highway to your heart as clear as possible so Jesus can ride straight in!

The words of John the Baptist are very much for us today. Jesus comes to us in his Word. Are we ready to receive him, or is the highway to our hearts blocked by something? Jesus is coming again on the Last Day, but are our eyes open to see him?

The good news is that no matter what, Jesus is coming with the salvation that he promised. Whatever debris and brush that still blocks the way, he'll clear it. Whatever mountains and valleys make his arrival harder; he'll level them. We look forward to his arrival and do everything we can to clear the path in advance—because we want him to reach us every day!

Jesus is coming. How cool is it that we get to prepare the way for the Lord! Come, Lord Jesus!

The questions below are to help families discuss this devotion. The questions are divided by age group as suggestions, but anyone could reflect on any of the questions as they desire.

Questions for the Younger Children

- What kinds of things make it hard to walk on a sidewalk?
- What kinds of things make it hard to pay attention to God's Word?

Questions for Elementary Age Children

- What kinds of preparations are you making for Christmas celebrations?
- What kinds of preparations can we make for Jesus the other 11 months of the year?

Questions for Middle School and Above

- Why is repentance such an important aspect of preparation for Jesus' arrival?
- Why was John the Baptist's work so valuable in God's plan?

Closing Prayer:

Lord Jesus, we love seeing you in your word, and we look forward to seeing you with our eyes. Give us the faith to clear the path for you into our own hearts and into the hearts of everyone we know. Amen.